THE DEPARTMENT OF STATE

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Concerning Policy Toward Japan

EXCHANGE OF LETTERS BETWEEN SENATOR WHERRY AND ACTING SECRETARY ACHESON

[Released to the press September 24]

SEPTEMBER 21, 1945.

DEAR MR. SECRETARY:

The confirmation of your nomination as Under Secretary of State is to be called up on the Senate Floor Monday. I am tremendously interested in the future policies of our Government which deal with demobilization and with laying the foundations for the restoration of peaceful relations among the nations of the world.

I was amazed to read in the Washington *Post* of Thursday, September 20th your rebuke of General MacArthur and your views relative to our future relationships with Japan. Inasmuch as I will be called upon to vote upon your nomination, I am anxious to know whether the following three statements from the *Post* are substantially correct in reflecting your views:

1. The United States Government not the Occupation Forces under General MacArthur is determining American policy toward Japan.

2. A decision on the part of the State Department for social and economic revolution in Japan.

3. In speaking of this Government's policy toward Japan, you said the policy would not be changed and that it would be carried out regardless of cost.

Mr. Secretary, do these statements reflect your attitude toward this Government's Japanese policy and toward MacArthur's administration of the task he has been assigned? Furthermore, I feel it my duty to direct the following questions to you and ask that you be good enough to forward your reply to me by Monday morning, at the latest, since my further interest in your confirmation will be largely conditioned by your answers.

1. Is General MacArthur acting as a representative only of the United States Government or of the Allied Governments as well in implementing the terms of the Potsdam agreement?

2. Do you know of any instance or instances wherein General MacArthur has evidenced any unwillingness to discharge his responsibilities as agent of the Allied Governments?

3. Are you wholeheartedly in agreement with the Potsdam Declaration?

4. Are not our dealings with Japan already honor bound by our commitment to the Potsdam Declaration?

5. Is there anything in the Potsdam Declaration which requires the Allied Nations to deal with Hirohito any differently than General MacArthur is now dealing with him?

6. Is there any provision in the Potsdam Declaration for any one of the Allied Governments deliberately to foster a social and economic revolution in Japan?

7. In implementing the provisions of this Declaration, do you believe that the judgment, the wisdom, and the magnanimity of spirit of General MacArthur's address aboard the USS *Missouri* could be surpassed when he said "Nor is it for us here to meet, representing as we do a majority of the peoples of the earth, in a spirit of distrust, malice, or hatred. But rather it is for us, both victors and vanquished, to rise to that higher dignity which alone benefits the sacred purposes we are about to serve, committing all of our people unreservedly to faithful compliance with the undertakings they are here formally to assume."

8. Is not the real ground for any quarrel between the State Department and General MacArthur the fact that he did not use the normal channels through which to transmit to the American people his conclusions as to his future needs in Japan, and if he had used the normal channels, what guarantee is there that the American people would have been informed?

9. If, after the few weeks that MacArthur has been in Tokyo, he has been able to revise his estimate of future needs so drastically, are not we warranted in assuming that General Eisenhower has made a similar revision? Do you know whether such a revision has been made by General Eisenhower and transmitted to this country, and, if so, whether that information has yet been given to the American people?

Because of the confusion which your statements have caused, you should have an opportunity to clarify them. I am sure there are a great number of American people who are as intensely interested in your answers as I will be. Therefore, I am

making this letter public and trust you will do the same with your reply.

Very truly yours

KENNETH S. WHERRY

SEPTEMBER 22, 1945

MY DEAR SENATOR WHERRY:

It is plain to me from your letter of September 21 that you have not had before you the statement which I made in response to a question from the press. I enclose the stenographic transcript of both question and answer. I also enclose a copy of the Potsdam proclamation, calling your attention specifically to paragraphs numbered *6* to *12*, and the statement of general policy relating to Japan which has been released by the White House.

With the documents before you, you will have the exact text of my answer and also the official pronouncements of the Government on the same subject with which to test the correctness of my statement.

Sincerely yours,

DEAN ACHESON
Acting Secretary

[Here follow enclosures, the texts of which have appeared in the BULLETIN:

1. Excerpt from stenographic transcript of the Acting Secretary of State's press conference of September 19, 1945. See BULLETIN of September 23, 1945, p. 427.
2. Copy of Potsdam proclamation. See BULLETIN of July 29, 1945, p. 137.
3. Copy of statement of general policy relating to Japan. See BULLETIN of September 23, 1945, p. 423.]

Authority of General MacArthur as Supreme Commander of the Allied Powers

[Released to the press by the White House September 24]

The text of a message transmitted on September 6 through the Joint Chiefs of Staff to General MacArthur follows. It was prepared jointly by the Department of State, the War Department, and the Navy Department and approved by the President on September 6. The message is a statement clarifying the authority which General MacArthur is to exercise in his position as Supreme Commander for the Allied powers.

"1. The authority of the Emperor and the Japanese Government to rule the State is subordinate to you as Supreme Commander for the Allied powers. You will exercise your authority as you deem proper to carry out your mission. Our relations with Japan do not rest on a contractual basis, but on an unconditional surrender. Since your authority is supreme, you will not entertain any question on the part of the Japanese as to its scope.

"2. Control of Japan shall be exercised through the Japanese Government to the extent that such an arrangement produces satisfactory results. This does not prejudice your right to act directly if required. You may enforce the orders issued by you by the employment of such measures as you deem necessary, including the use of force.

"3. The statement of intentions contained in the Potsdam Declaration will be given full effect. It will not be given effect, however, because we consider ourselves bound in a contractual relationship with Japan as a result of that document. It will be respected and given effect because the Potsdam Declaration [1] forms a part of our policy stated in good faith with relation to Japan and with relation to peace and security in the Far East."

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[1] The Proclamation Defining Terms for Japanese Surrender appears in the BULLETIN of July 29, 1945, p. 137. The message from the Japanese Government to the Government of the United States referred to this proclamation as follows: "The Japanese Government are ready to accept the terms enumerated in the joint *declaration* which was issued at Potsdam on July 26th, 1945, by the heads of the Governments of the United States, Great Britain, and China, and later subscribed by the Soviet Government, with the understanding that the said *declaration* does not comprise any demand which prejudices the prerogatives of His Majesty as a Sovereign Ruler." See BULLETIN of Aug. 12, 1945, p. 205.

This proclamation was issued while the Tripartite Conference of Berlin was in progress at the Cecilienhof near Potsdam. See BULLETIN of Aug. 5, 1945, p. 153.

The Instrument of Surrender, in which Japan accepted the "provisions set forth in the *declaration* issued by the heads of the Governments of the United States, China and Great Britain on 26 July 1945, at Potsdam, and subsequently adhered to by the Union of Soviet Socialist Republics . . ." appears on pages 364–65 of the BULLETIN of Sept. 9, 1945.

Italics are the editor's.